

# MARKETING MANAGEMENT

Course Code: IM345AT | Semester IV | L:T:P 3:0:0 | 45 Hours

## UNIT I

### Introduction to Digital Marketing & Content Marketing

Unit I sets the foundation for the whole course. It begins with what marketing itself means, moves into the principles and channels of digital marketing, shows how to build a buyer persona and research competitors, and closes with the complete content marketing engine — planning, creating, distributing, promoting and measuring content.

#### TOPICS COVERED IN THIS UNIT

**Introduction to Digital Marketing:** Principles of Digital Marketing; Digital Marketing Channels; Tools to Create Buyer Persona; Competitor Research Tools; Website Analysis Tools.

**Content Marketing:** Content Marketing Concepts & Strategies; Planning, Creating, Distributing & Promoting Content; Optimize Website UX & Landing Pages; Measure Impact; Metrics & Performance; Using Content Research for Opportunities.

#### ABOUT THESE NOTES

These notes are **unofficial**. They have been documented by students from **Vikram Sir's handwritten notes, lecture slides and classroom sessions**, and restructured to follow the official IM345AT syllabus unit by unit. Where the source notes were incomplete, the gaps have been filled from standard marketing-management texts and clearly integrated into the same flow. Every previous-year question in the question bank at the end has been extracted verbatim from the actual RVCE CIE and SEE papers for this course. This document is a study aid and is not issued, endorsed or verified by the Department of Industrial Engineering and Management or by RV College of Engineering. Always cross-check against the official syllabus and your own class notes.



| Semester: IV                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |   |         |  |              |              |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---|---------|--|--------------|--------------|
| MARKETING MANAGEMENT                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |   |         |  |              |              |
| Category: Professional Core Course<br>(Theory)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |   |         |  |              |              |
| Course Code                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               | : | IM345AT |  | CIE Marks    | : 100 Marks  |
| Credits: L:T:P                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            | : | 3:0:0   |  | SEE Marks    | : 100 Marks  |
| Total Hours                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               | : | 45L     |  | SEE Duration | : 3.00 Hours |
| UNIT-I                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |   |         |  |              | 07Hrs        |
| <b>Introduction to Digital Marketing:</b> Principles of Digital Marketing; Digital Marketing Channels; Tools to Create Buyer Persona; Competitor Research Tools, Website Analysis Tools, etc.<br><b>Content Marketing:</b> Content Marketing Concepts & Strategies; Planning, Creating, Distributing & Promoting Content; Optimize Website UX & Landing Pages; Measure Impact; Metrics & Performance; Using Content Research for Opportunities, etc.      |   |         |  |              |              |
| UNIT-II                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |   |         |  |              | 08Hrs        |
| <b>Social Media Marketing:</b> Introduction; Major Social Media Platforms for Marketing; Developing Data-driven Audience & Campaign Insights; Social Media for Business; Creation & Optimization of Social Media Campaigns, etc. <b>Search Engine Optimization:</b> Search Engine Optimization Fundamentals; Keywords and SEO Content Plan; SEO & Business Objectives; Writing SEO Content; On-site & off-site SEO; Optimize Organic Search Ranking, etc. |   |         |  |              |              |
| UNIT-III                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  |   |         |  |              | 07Hrs        |
| <b>Web Analytics &amp; Google Analytics:</b> Google Analytics Tools; Web Analytics Tools, etc.<br><b>E-mail Marketing:</b> Effective E-mail Campaigns; E-mail Plan; E-mail Marketing Campaign Analysis; Measuring Conversions & keeping up, etc.                                                                                                                                                                                                          |   |         |  |              |              |
| UNIT-IV                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |   |         |  |              | 07Hrs        |
| <b>Web Design:</b> Web design, optimization of websites; Publishing a basic website; User-centered Design and Website Optimization; Design Principles and Website Copy; Website Metrics & Developing Insight, etc.<br><b>Mobile Marketing:</b> Difference between mobile advertising and marketing, utilizing mobile marketing for sales promotions, online applications, etc.                                                                            |   |         |  |              |              |
| UNIT-V                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |   |         |  |              | 07Hrs        |
| <b>Conversion Optimization:</b> What is AIDAS and its role; website optimization; what visitors want to see on the website; how to optimize key element and increase the effect of landing on a particular page<br><b>Digital Analytics:</b> Evolution of Digital Analytics, information about end-to-end customer experience, analyst's influence on business, role as a change agent, etc.                                                              |   |         |  |              |              |

| Course Outcomes: After completing the course, the students will be able to |                                                                                                                                                                                          |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| CO1                                                                        | Differentiate the benefits drawn by updated marketing mix from traditional marketing mix for effective marketing management there by to stay competitive in today's global market-place. |
| CO2                                                                        | Develop an effective holistic marketing atmosphere to efficiently face the challenges in dynamically changing market.                                                                    |
| CO3                                                                        | Formulate a potential marketing plan to effectively reach the targeted market segments, by delivering the value to targeted customers through practicing sound marketing research.       |
| CO4                                                                        | Create new channels to improvise marketing to achieve and maintain competitive position in globalized market-place.                                                                      |

| Reference Books |                                                                                                                                                                                      |
|-----------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1.              | Marketing Management, Philip Kotler, Kevin Lane Keller, 15 <sup>th</sup> Edition, 2016, Pearson, ISBN:978-93-325-5718-5                                                              |
| 2.              | Digital Marketing - Strategy, Implementation & Practice, Dave Chaffey, Fiona Ellis – Chadwick, 7 <sup>th</sup> Edition, 2019, Pearson, ISBN - 9781292241623, 1292241624              |
| 3.              | Marketing Research, Donald S Tull, Del I Hawkins, 6 <sup>th</sup> Edition, Prentice Hall India, ISBN: 8120309618                                                                     |
| 4.              | Marketing Management - A South Asian Perspective, Philip Kotler, Kevin Lane Keller, Abraham Koshy, MithileshwarJha, 14 <sup>th</sup> Edition, 2013, Pearson, ISBN –978-81-317-6716-0 |
| 5.              | Marketing Research, David A. Aaker, V. Kumar, George S. Day, 9 <sup>th</sup> Edition, 2008, John Wiley & Sons, ISBN: 978-265-1791-6                                                  |



| RUBRIC FOR THE CONTINUOUS INTERNAL EVALUATION (THEORY) |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           |            |
|--------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------|
| #                                                      | COMPONENTS                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                | MARKS      |
| 1.                                                     | <b>QUIZZES:</b> Quizzes will be conducted in online/offline mode. TWO QUIZZES will be conducted & Each Quiz will be evaluated for 10 Marks. <b>THE SUM OF TWO QUIZZES WILL BE THE FINAL QUIZ MARKS.</b>                                                                                                                                                                   | <b>20</b>  |
| 2.                                                     | <b>TESTS:</b> Students will be evaluated in test, descriptive questions with different complexity levels (Revised Bloom's Taxonomy Levels: Remembering, Understanding, Applying, Analyzing, Evaluating, and Creating). TWO tests will be conducted. Each test will be evaluated for 50 Marks, adding upto 100 Marks. <b>FINAL TEST MARKS WILL BE REDUCED TO 40 MARKS.</b> | <b>40</b>  |
| 3.                                                     | <b>EXPERIENTIAL LEARNING:</b> Students will be evaluated for their creativity and practical implementation of the problem. Case study-based teaching learning (10), Program specific requirements (10), Video based seminar/presentation/demonstration (20) <b>ADDING UPTO 40</b>                                                                                         | <b>40</b>  |
| <b>MAXIMUM MARKS FOR THE CIE THEORY</b>                |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           | <b>100</b> |

| RUBRIC FOR SEMESTER END EXAMINATION (THEORY)         |                                                   |            |
|------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|------------|
| Q. NO.                                               | CONTENTS                                          | MARKS      |
| <b>PART A</b>                                        |                                                   |            |
| 1                                                    | Objective type questions covering entire syllabus | 20         |
| <b>PART B</b><br>(Maximum of TWO Sub-divisions only) |                                                   |            |
| 2                                                    | Unit 1: (Compulsory)                              | 16         |
| 3 & 4                                                | Unit 2: (Internal Choice)                         | 16         |
| 5 & 6                                                | Unit 3: (Internal Choice)                         | 16         |
| 7 & 8                                                | Unit 4: (Internal Choice)                         | 16         |
| 9 & 10                                               | Unit 5: (Internal Choice)                         | 16         |
| <b>TOTAL</b>                                         |                                                   | <b>100</b> |

## 1.0 Foundations — What Marketing Actually Is

Digital marketing is not a separate discipline from marketing; it is marketing conducted through digital channels. Every previous CIE paper for this course has opened Part A with a foundation question (*mantra of marketing, core concepts of marketing, entities that can be marketed, marketplace vs market space*), so this section must be secure before anything else.

### 1.0.1 Definition of Marketing Management

#### DEFINITION

**Marketing Management** is the art and science of choosing target markets and getting, keeping and growing customers through creating, delivering and communicating superior customer value.

Three ideas are packed into that sentence. *Choosing target markets* is a selection decision — you cannot serve everybody. *Getting, keeping and growing* is a lifecycle view — acquisition alone is not marketing. *Creating, delivering and communicating superior value* is the actual work.

### 1.0.2 The Mantra of Marketing

#### EXAM ANSWER — asked in CIE-I, 3 April 2025 (2 marks)

**Create — Communicate — Deliver — Value — Target — Profit.**

The firm *creates* value, *communicates* it to a chosen *target*, *delivers* it, and in return earns *profit*.

### 1.0.3 Why Marketing Matters — Three Pillars

1. **Financial success** — a firm's financial performance often depends directly on its marketing ability; the best operations and finance are worthless if there is insufficient demand.
2. **Economic engine** — successful marketing builds demand for products and services, and that demand creates jobs.
3. **Intangible assets** — marketing builds strong brands and a loyal customer base, which contribute heavily to the firm's overall enterprise value.

### 1.0.4 Selling is Only the Tip of the Iceberg

Selling and marketing are not synonyms. Selling is the visible tip; marketing is the enormous mass below the waterline — research, segmentation, positioning, product design, pricing, channel design and communication. There will always be a need for *some* selling, but the aim of marketing is to make selling superfluous.

#### PETER DRUCKER ON MARKETING

“The aim of marketing is to make selling superfluous. The aim is to know and understand the customer so well that the product or service fits him and sells itself. Ideally marketing should result in a customer who is ready to buy. All that should be needed then is to make the product or service available.”

### 1.0.5 The Ten Entities That Can Be Marketed

A full 10-mark question in CIE-I (April 2025) asked students to *identify and explain the various entities that can be marketed, providing relevant examples for each category*. The official scheme lists exactly ten.

| Entity               | What is marketed                                                          | Example                                              |
|----------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Goods</b>         | Physical, tangible products — the bulk of most nations' production        | Cars, smartphones, packaged food                     |
| <b>Services</b>      | Intangible performances that cannot be stored                             | Airlines, banking, hotels, salons, consultants       |
| <b>Events</b>        | Time-based occasions promoted to an audience                              | Olympics, trade fairs, IPL, company anniversaries    |
| <b>Experiences</b>   | Orchestrated combinations of goods and services                           | Disneyland, adventure treks, escape rooms            |
| <b>Persons</b>       | Celebrity/personal branding                                               | Sportspersons, actors, CEOs, political leaders       |
| <b>Places</b>        | Cities, states, regions and nations competing for tourists and investment | "Incredible India", Singapore, Dubai                 |
| <b>Properties</b>    | Intangible rights of ownership — real or financial                        | Real estate, stocks, bonds                           |
| <b>Organizations</b> | The institution itself as a brand                                         | Universities, NGOs, corporate brand campaigns        |
| <b>Information</b>   | Production, packaging and distribution of knowledge                       | Encyclopaedias, magazines, schools, market research  |
| <b>Ideas</b>         | Social causes and concepts                                                | "Swachh Bharat", anti-smoking, road-safety campaigns |

### 1.0.6 Core Concepts — Needs, Wants and Demands

**Needs** — the basic human requirements — air, food, water, clothing, shelter, and at a higher level recreation, education and entertainment. Needs are not created by marketers.

**Wants** — needs directed at *specific objects* that might satisfy them. Wants are shaped by society, culture and individual personality. An Indian consumer *needs* food but *wants* a masala dosa.

**Demands** — wants for a specific product backed by an *ability and willingness to pay*. Many people want a Mercedes; only a few can demand one.

#### EXAM POINT — CIE-I 2026 Part A

"Mention any two core concepts of marketing" — acceptable answers are any two of: **needs, wants, demand, value, exchange, markets** (and in extended lists: target markets, segmentation, positioning, offerings, brands, satisfaction, supply chain, competition, marketing environment).

### 1.0.7 The Value Creation Engine

Value moves through the organisation in three connected steps.

1. **The audience** — *target markets, segmentation and positioning*. Identifying who to serve and where to stand in their mind.
2. **The solution** — the *value proposition* (the set of benefits offered to satisfy the need), the *offering* (the combination of products, services, information and experiences that delivers it), and the *brand* (an offering from a known source).
3. **The result** — *value* (the combination of quality, service and price, the "QSP triad") and *satisfaction* (a person's judgement of a product's perceived performance compared with expectations).

**SATISFACTION FORMULA**

If **performance < expectations** → the customer is *dissatisfied*.

If **performance = expectations** → the customer is *satisfied*.

If **performance > expectations** → the customer is *delighted* — and delight, not mere satisfaction, is what produces advocacy.

**1.0.8 Marketplace vs Market Space****EXAM ANSWER — asked in CIE-I 2025 AND CIE-I 2026 (2 marks each time)**

**Marketplace** is a *physical or digital location* where buyers and sellers come together to exchange goods and services — it is concrete (a mall, a mandi, a showroom).

**Market space** is a *conceptual or virtual environment* in which commercial value is created through digital networks and communication technologies — it is abstract and has no geography (Amazon, an app, a marketplace platform).

One-line contrast: *marketplace = physical, market space = digital*.

A third related term is the **metamarket** — a cluster of complementary products and services that are closely related in the mind of the consumer but spread across different industries (the automobile metamarket contains manufacturers, dealers, insurers, financiers, service centres and auto magazines).

**1.0.9 Push vs Pull Marketing**

| Basis                    | Push Marketing                                                                                                  | Pull Marketing                                                          |
|--------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Definition</b>        | The brand <i>pushes</i> the product towards the customer                                                        | The brand <i>encourages</i> customers to actively seek it out           |
| <b>Direction</b>         | Producer → channel → consumer                                                                                   | Consumer → producer                                                     |
| <b>Typical tools</b>     | TV/print advertising, trade discounts, dealer incentives, direct selling, telemarketing, point-of-sale displays | SEO, content marketing, social media, word of mouth, brand building, PR |
| <b>Consumer state</b>    | Passive; unaware of the need                                                                                    | Active; already searching                                               |
| <b>Demand created by</b> | The seller                                                                                                      | The buyer                                                               |
| <b>Cost pattern</b>      | High recurring spend; stops when spend stops                                                                    | High upfront effort; compounds over time                                |
| <b>Best for</b>          | New products, impulse goods, low-involvement purchases                                                          | Established brands, high-involvement and considered purchases           |

**HIGH-YIELD**

Push vs pull has been asked in **CIE-I 2025, CIE-I 2026 and the SEE of June/July 2025**. It is the single most repeated 2-mark question in this course. Learn the definitions verbatim and keep two examples ready.

**1.0.10 Evolution of Company Orientations**

| Orientation               | Central belief                                                      | Focus                                                 |
|---------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Production concept</b> | Consumers prefer products that are widely available and inexpensive | Manufacturing efficiency, mass distribution, low cost |

| Orientation               | Central belief                                                                                | Focus                                                                    |
|---------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Product concept</b>    | Consumers favour products offering the most quality, performance or innovative features       | Continuous product improvement                                           |
| <b>Selling concept</b>    | Consumers will not buy enough unless prodded                                                  | Aggressive promotion and a large sales force — the “tip of the iceberg”  |
| <b>Marketing concept</b>  | Find the right <i>products for your customers</i> , not the right customers for your products | Customer needs, integrated marketing, profitability through satisfaction |
| <b>Holistic marketing</b> | Everything matters in marketing and a broad, integrated perspective is necessary              | Internal, integrated, performance and relationship marketing             |

### 1.0.11 Holistic Marketing — Four Dimensions

- **Internal marketing** — aligning the marketing department, senior management and every other department so that the whole firm embraces marketing principles.
- **Integrated marketing** — designing communications, products & services, channels and price so that they reinforce rather than contradict one another.
- **Performance marketing** — measuring returns: sales revenue, brand equity, customer equity, plus the ethical, environmental, legal and social effects of marketing activity.
- **Relationship marketing** — building deep, enduring relationships with the four constituents who sustain the business: customers, employees, marketing partners and the financial community.

### 1.0.12 The Marketing Mix — 4 Ps

| PRODUCT                                                                                                 | PRICE                                                           | PLACE                                                            | PROMOTION                                                                     |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Product variety, Quality, Design, Features, Brand name, Packaging, Sizes, Services, Warranties, Returns | List price, Discounts, Allowances, Payment period, Credit terms | Channels, Coverage, Assortments, Locations, Inventory, Transport | Sales promotion, Advertising, Sales force, Public relations, Direct marketing |

#### How the 4 Ps evolved in the digital era (CIE-I 2025, 10 marks)

| P                | Digital evolution                                                                                                                                      | Company example                                                                                                           |
|------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Product</b>   | Digital and personalised products; customisable, data-driven, and increasingly delivered in digital formats (software, online services, virtual goods) | <b>Spotify</b> uses listening data to generate personalised playlists, making the product itself different for every user |
| <b>Price</b>     | Dynamic and transparent pricing; real-time price changes, personalised offers and instant comparison by the customer                                   | <b>Amazon</b> uses AI to adjust prices dynamically based on demand, competition and user behaviour                        |
| <b>Place</b>     | Online channels and omnichannel presence; a shift from physical stores to e-commerce, apps and marketplaces with a seamless online–offline experience  | <b>Nike</b> links its website, mobile app and physical stores through click-and-collect and store locator                 |
| <b>Promotion</b> | Digital and interactive marketing; a shift from mass media to targeted digital campaigns, social media, influencer and content marketing               | <b>Coca-Cola</b> — the “Share a Coke” campaign ran as interactive, personalised, shareable digital content                |

Modern extensions add three service Ps — **People, Process and Physical evidence** — giving the 7 Ps of services marketing; and the customer-side mirror of the 4 Ps is the **4 Cs**: Customer solution, Customer cost, Convenience and Communication.

### 1.0.13 The Market Ecosystem and the Profit Equation

An **industry** is a collection of sellers; a **market** is a collection of buyers. Sellers send *communication* and *goods and services* to the market; buyers send back *money* and *information*. The whole loop resolves into one equation.

#### THE PROFIT EQUATION

**Profit = Revenues – Costs.** Every marketing decision either raises revenue (more customers, higher price, more purchases per customer) or lowers cost (cheaper acquisition, better retention, more efficient channels). If it does neither, it is not marketing — it is decoration.

**Supply chain** — the longer channel stretching from raw materials to components to finished products carried to final buyers. For coffee: Ethiopian farmers grow and harvest → sell to a Fair Trade cooperative → beans washed, dried and packaged → an Alternative Trading Organisation transports them → sold through retail channels. Each link captures a share of the total value.

**Competition** — all the actual and potential rival offerings and substitutes that a buyer might consider — not just direct competitors but anything competing for the same need and the same rupee.

### 1.0.14 The Eight Marketing Management Tasks

1. Developing market strategies and plans
2. Capturing marketing insights
3. Connecting with customers
4. Building strong brands
5. Creating value
6. Delivering value
7. Communicating value
8. Creating successful long-term growth — which loops back to task 1



# 1.1 Introduction to Digital Marketing

## 1.1.1 What Digital Marketing Is

### DEFINITION

**Digital Marketing** is the well-targeted, conversion-oriented, quantifiable and interactive marketing of products or services using digital technologies, in order to reach customers, convert them into clients and retain them in a sustainable fashion.

Today's internet has opened the gateway to enormous marketing opportunity. Through digital channels a business does not merely *share* its products and services online — it can attract prospects, engage them, and convert them into paying customers, all while measuring every step. The speed and simplicity with which digital media transmits information and supports a business is what makes it structurally different from everything that came before.

The world is now super-connected, and marketing and advertising are no longer what they once were. This is particularly true because of the rise of social networking, which has changed how organisations speak with potential and existing customers. Digital marketing is an aggregate term used where advertising and marketing meet web technology and online media platforms.

### THE CENTRAL IDEA OF THIS COURSE

"Digital marketing isn't about technology; it's about **people**." Technology is only interesting, from a marketing perspective, when it connects people with other people more effectively. Understanding the underlying code is secondary; understanding the human being on the other side of the screen is the job.

## 1.1.2 Traditional Marketing

Traditional marketing lets businesses promote their products or services on print media, radio and TV commercials, billboards, business cards and numerous similar channels where the internet and social platforms are not used.

- Traditional approaches had **constrained reach** and limited scope to influence buying behaviour; they were also **not quantifiable**.
- Tangible forms include business cards, print ads in newspapers and magazines, posters, brochures, TV and radio commercials and billboards. Traditional marketing is essentially *anything except digital means* of branding a product or logo.
- An often overlooked form is **referral and networking** — people find a business through a referral and a rapport is built over time.
- Because of its longevity, people are **accustomed** to it. Reading a billboard or spotting an ad in a magazine remain familiar everyday activities.
- It usually reaches a **local audience**, even though it is not strictly limited to one.
- Where it still wins: targeting a local audience, materials that are physically kept, a more personal feel, and a simpler process.
- Its primary weaknesses: results are **not easily measured** and often cannot be measured at all; it is generally **more costly**; and it is **static** — there is no way to interact with the audience. You are throwing information in front of people and hoping they act.

## 1.1.3 Traditional vs Digital Marketing — The Master Comparison

This comparison has appeared as a 10-mark question in CIE-I (2025 and 2026) and as an 8-mark SEE question (Oct/Nov 2023, Q2a: “*Highlight any 5 key differences*”). Learn at least seven rows.

| Aspect                   | Traditional Marketing                                          | Digital Marketing                                                           |
|--------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Communication</b>     | Unidirectional — the organisation talks <i>at</i> its audience | Bidirectional — customers ask questions, complain and make suggestions back |
| <b>Medium</b>            | Phone calls, letters, print, TV, radio, billboards             | Social media, websites, chat, apps, e-mail, SEO, PPC                        |
| <b>Reach</b>             | Local, or mass depending on medium; geographically restricted  | Global and theoretically infinite, yet laser-targeted                       |
| <b>Cost</b>              | Often expensive — TV, print production, media buying           | Cost-effective — pay-per-click and organic reach options                    |
| <b>Targeting</b>         | Broad and imprecise                                            | Precise — age, location, interests, behaviour, intent                       |
| <b>Interactivity</b>     | One-way communication                                          | Two-way, real-time engagement                                               |
| <b>Measurability</b>     | Hard to track ROI accurately; largely unquantifiable           | Easily trackable with analytics and KPIs, in real time                      |
| <b>Flexibility</b>       | Less flexible once launched; rigid, long-term campaigns        | Highly flexible; adjustable in real time                                    |
| <b>Time to launch</b>    | Requires long planning and production cycles                   | Quick to launch, refine and adapt                                           |
| <b>Direction of pull</b> | Outbound — push                                                | Inbound — the goal is for people to <i>find you</i>                         |

### **Strategy for transitioning from traditional to digital (the 10-mark answer)**

1. **Start with a hybrid approach** — run both in parallel initially rather than cutting traditional spend overnight.
2. **Build the owned foundation** — a quality company website and social media presence.
3. **Layer on SEO and content marketing** — blogs, videos, landing pages, to build compounding organic traffic.
4. **Run targeted paid ads** — Google Ads and social media ads to buy immediate reach while organic builds.
5. **Leverage e-mail marketing and influencers** for retention and credibility.
6. **Track performance with analytics tools**, defining KPIs before launch.
7. **Gradually reduce traditional spending** based on measured results, not assumption.
8. **Upskill or hire** — train the existing team or bring in a dedicated digital marketing expert.

## 1.2 Principles of Digital Marketing

“Describe the key principles of digital marketing and explain how they differ from traditional marketing approaches” was a full 10-mark CIE-I question (1.07.2024), and “List any 2 principles of digital marketing” was a 2-mark SEE question (Oct/Nov 2023). The principles below are the examinable set.

### 1.2.1 The Five Foundational Pillars

There is no one-size-fits-all strategy. Every business must bake its own, and the best people to define it are the people who best know the business. But every workable digital strategy rests on the same five foundations.

1. **Know your business.** Is the business ready to embrace digital marketing? Are the products or services suited to online promotion? Is the right technology, skill set and infrastructure in place? How will digital marketing fit into existing business processes — do those processes need to change, and are the staff ready for that change?
2. **Know the competition.** Who are the main competitors in the *digital* marketplace — are they the same as the offline ones? What are they doing right (emulate it), what are they doing wrong (learn from it), and what are they *not doing at all* (that is the opportunity)? Competition online can come from around the corner or around the globe, so never limit the analysis to local rivals.
3. **Know your customers.** Who are they and what do they want? Are you serving the same customer base online, or fishing in a new demographic? How do they use digital technology, and how can that be harnessed into an ongoing relationship?
4. **Know what you want to achieve.** If you don't know where you're going, you will never get there. Set clear, measurable, achievable goals — online sales, targeted leads, brand awareness — because goals are the yardsticks against which campaign progress is measured.
5. **Know how you're doing.** Everything online is trackable. Which channels deliver traffic? What are the conversion rates? How much of that traffic becomes tangible value? *Measure, tweak, refine, re-measure.*

### 1.2.2 The Internet Paradox

#### THE INTERNET PARADOX — a favourite exam line

Unlike conventional mass media, the internet is unique in its capacity to **both broaden the scope of your marketing reach and narrow its focus at the same time**. Digital channels let you transcend geography and time zones to reach a far wider audience, while simultaneously honing the message with laser-like precision onto very specific niche segments within that wider market. Implemented well, it is an extraordinarily powerful combination.

### 1.2.3 Other Governing Principles

- **Measurability** — every interaction leaves a quantifiable data trail; if it cannot be measured, it should not be a channel.
- **Interactivity** — marketing in the digital age is a *dialogue*, as much about listening as about telling.
- **Personalisation** — digital marketing allows uniquely tailored, ongoing relationships with individual customers rather than an undifferentiated mass.
- **Permission and user control** — the web is not a passive medium; marketing must be user-centric, elective and permission-based, or the audience will actively *disengage*.
- **Integration** — channels must reinforce one another; a siloed campaign wastes the compounding effect.

- **Iteration** — digital marketing is never “finished”. It is a continuous engine: **Execute strategy** → **Measure analytics** → **Tweak campaigns** → **Refine goals** → **repeat**.
- **Content centrality** — ‘Content is King’. Produce powerful, genuine, compelling content and in time that content becomes the biggest promoter of the brand.

### 1.2.4 Characteristics of a Successful Digital Marketing Campaign

Campaigns differ enormously, but successful ones are built on the same few key elements.

1. **A quality company website.** What was a novelty a decade ago is a critical requirement today. A business website is a pseudo-B2B portal that lets businesses and customers around the world connect with you — a company brochure available 24×7 that projects you as a professional outfit.
2. **Social media presence.** Facebook, Instagram, LinkedIn, X/Twitter, Pinterest and YouTube let you communicate across wide demographics of age, taste and culture. By actively promoting the company there, you get the world to talk about you.
3. **Blogging and forums.** Produce genuine, compelling content on the company blog and be a regular on relevant forums and discussion panels. Learn the art of connecting business themes into the content you produce.
4. **Local listing services.** Register on Google Business Profile (Google Places) so the business appears in Google searches and on Google Maps; also list on Bing Places and equivalent directories. Joining is free and the reach translates into free promotion.
5. **E-mail marketing.** Done well and with good intentions, personalised e-mail speaks directly to the target audience, produces an immediate response and opens a line of communication with prospects — fast, cheap promotion with measurable feedback.
6. **A dedicated digital marketing expert.** Hiring a professional lets you stay on top of promotional ideas while someone qualified implements the concepts that drive the expected results.

## 1.3 Technology Behind Digital Marketing

Developments in technology and the evolution of marketing are inextricably intertwined. The adoption pattern is always the same.

1. New technology emerges and is initially the preserve of technologists and early adopters.
2. It gains a firmer foothold, becomes popular, and appears on the marketing radar.
3. Innovative marketers explore ways to harness it to connect with their target audience.
4. The technology migrates to the mainstream and is absorbed into standard marketing practice.

The printing press, radio, television and now the internet are all breakthroughs that permanently altered the relationship between marketers and consumers, on a global scale.

### 1.3.1 Timeline — From Sputnik to the World Wide Web

| Year          | Milestone                                                                                                                                     | Why it matters to marketers                                                              |
|---------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1957          | USSR launches <i>Sputnik</i>                                                                                                                  | Signals the US is falling behind; triggers heavy US investment in science and technology |
| 1958          | US Department of Defense sets up <b>ARPA</b> (Advanced Research Projects Agency)                                                              | The institutional parent of the internet                                                 |
| early 1960s   | E-mail exists only <i>within</i> single mainframes                                                                                            | The “killer application” is born, but cannot yet cross machines                          |
| 1971          | <b>Ray Tomlinson</b> writes the first program to send mail between host computers on ARPANET; chooses the @ symbol to separate user from host | E-mail becomes a network application — as a programmer's afterthought                    |
| 1974          | <b>Vinton Cerf</b> (“father of the internet”) and Robert Kahn define the TCP protocol at DARPA                                                | Different networks can now be interconnected                                             |
| 1983          | ARPANET adopts <b>TCP/IP</b> ; the <b>domain name system</b> (.com, .net) is invented                                                         | Widely considered the true “birth” of the internet                                       |
| 1984–89       | Nodes pass 1,000, then 100,000 hosts                                                                                                          | Network effects begin                                                                    |
| 1989          | <b>Tim Berners-Lee</b> at CERN proposes cross-referencing documents across the internet using <b>hypertext</b>                                | The concept of the World Wide Web                                                        |
| 6 August 1991 | The first web page goes online at CERN                                                                                                        | The web becomes a public medium                                                          |
| 2000s+        | Dot-com boom and <b>Web 2.0</b>                                                                                                               | User-generated content; the global village                                               |

#### FRAMING FOR THE EXAM

If asked about “technology behind digital marketing”, structure the answer as: (i) the adoption pattern (4 steps above), (ii) the timeline of enabling technologies, (iii) the present-day technology stack — websites and CMS, search engines and their ranking algorithms, social platforms and their feed algorithms, analytics and tag management, e-mail service providers and CRM, mobile devices and apps, cloud infrastructure, and increasingly AI/machine learning for personalisation and pricing.

## 1.4 Understanding the Digital Consumer

### 1.4.1 The Myth and the Reality

There is a notion in marketing circles of mysterious, ethereal creatures who exist in a hyper-connected cyber-world of their own — enigmas who speak a different language and are turning marketing on its head. The first thing to realise about digital consumers is that **there is basically no such thing**. The customers you encounter online are the very same people who walk into your store, call you on the telephone, or order from your catalogue.

They are doing exactly what people have done for thousands of years — communicating with each other. The fact that technology enables them to do it faster, over distance and across devices is perceived as dangerous and extraordinary, but people have always talked to each other. What *has* genuinely changed is consumer **behaviour**, and it has changed because of the pervasive, evocative and enabling nature of digital technology.

Consumers do not care how marketers categorise their work. Above the line, below the line, digital, traditional, experiential, linear, analogue, mobile, direct, indirect — all of these boxes are meaningless to them. **All consumers care about is the experience** and whether the marketing available to them helps them make a more informed decision.

### 1.4.2 Perceived Anonymity

Perceived anonymity is an online trait with a profound effect on behaviour. It liberates consumers from the social shackles that bind them in the real world; online they act with scant regard for the social propriety that holds sway in real life. In a physical store shoppers wait patiently for service and will endure a less-than-perfect experience to get what they want. Online they will not. They demand instant gratification and a flawless experience, and if you fail to engage, retain and fulfil their expectations on demand they are gone — the only trace a solitary line in your server log.

### 1.4.3 The Five Key Traits of the Online Consumer

| Trait                                            | What it means                                                                                                                        | What the marketer must therefore do                                                                               |
|--------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>1. Comfortable with the medium</b>            | Users have been online for years and are increasingly web-savvy across all age groups; they use it efficiently and don't hang around | Deliver what they want, fast; write scannable content                                                             |
| <b>2. They want it all, and they want it now</b> | Accustomed to information on demand from multiple sources simultaneously; their time is precious                                     | Design for "scannability" and instant gratification; front-load the value                                         |
| <b>3. They're in control</b>                     | The web is no passive medium; Web 2.0 put users firmly in charge                                                                     | Make marketing user-centric, elective and permission-based, with a real value proposition                         |
| <b>4. They're fickle</b>                         | Transparency and immediacy erode brand loyalty; competitors are one click and one search away                                        | Build genuine trust; make sure the <i>total</i> value proposition stacks up globally, not just the brand identity |
| <b>5. They're vocal</b>                          | Through reviews, blogs, social networks, forums and communities they tell each other about good <i>and</i> bad experiences           | Harness the viral upside; monitor and respond, because the same mechanism can produce a backlash                  |

### 1.4.4 Consumer 2.0 — How Web 2.0 Rewired Behaviour

- **Inter-connectivity** — borderless peer-to-peer communication through social networks.
- **On-demand** — instant gratification, anytime and anywhere.

- **Levelled information** — unbiased research is freely available, shifting power decisively to the buyer.
- **Rise of the 'prosumer'** — customers now help shape and even dictate the products they consume.
- **Relevance filtering** — users block noise and customise their own feeds; irrelevant marketing is simply never seen.
- **Niche aggregation** — mass markets fragment into thousands of micro-communities.
- **Micropublishing** — anyone can publish opinions, reviews and blogs instantly.

### 1.4.5 Online Influencers

One category of user deserves special mention when defining a digital strategy. **Influencers** are early adopters and online opinion leaders who, through blogs, podcasts, forums and social networks, extol the virtues of brands they like and denigrate those they find unsatisfactory. They matter because they hold the *virtual ear of the online masses* — people read them, value their opinion and trust their judgement. Engage positively and you recruit a team of powerful advocates; give them a negative experience and the reverse happens, at the same scale. This is word-of-mouth marketing on steroids.

#### ***The DoubleClick definition — how to recognise an influencer***

A person qualifies as an influencer if they strongly agree with three or more of the following:

- They consider themselves expert in certain areas (work, hobbies or interests).
- People often ask their advice about purchases in areas where they are knowledgeable.
- When they encounter a new product they like, they tend to recommend it to friends.
- They have a large social circle and often refer people to one another based on interests.
- They are active online — using blogs, social networking sites, e-mail, discussion groups and community boards to connect with peers.

#### **WHY WORD OF MOUTH DOMINATES**

Roughly **90%** of people believe what their peers say about a brand, while only about **48%** trust what businesses say directly. Americans value word-of-mouth recommendations from friends and family about **41% more** than social media recommendations. This asymmetry is the entire economic case for content marketing, influencer marketing and community building.

## 1.5 Digital Marketing Channels

### 1.5.1 The Three Core Channel Functions

Before listing platforms, note that “channel” in marketing has three distinct senses.

- **Communication channels** — deliver and receive messages from target buyers.
- **Distribution channels** — display, sell or deliver the physical product or service to the buyer.
- **Service channels** — carry out transactions with prospective buyers (warehouses, transporters, banks, payment gateways, insurers).

### 1.5.2 The Paid – Owned – Earned Media Taxonomy

This is the single most useful way to classify digital channels, and the CIE-I 2026 Part B question explicitly asked for “distribution platforms (owned, earned, paid media)”.

| Media type    | Definition                                     | Examples                                                                                                 | Role                                                                    |
|---------------|------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Owned</b>  | Assets entirely controlled by the brand        | Company website, blog, mobile app, e-mail list, brand social profiles, brochures                         | <b>The foundation</b> — no rent, full control, compounds over time      |
| <b>Paid</b>   | Capital deployed for guaranteed reach          | Display ads, paid search/PPC, social media ads, sponsorships, magazine and TV ads, influencer promotions | <b>The accelerator</b> — instant reach, stops the moment spending stops |
| <b>Earned</b> | Audience-driven reach that you did not pay for | Word of mouth, buzz, viral sharing, press coverage, reviews, influencer mentions, backlinks              | <b>The validator</b> — most credible, least controllable                |

#### RENTED vs OWNED

**Advertising is a rented treadmill. Content is an owned asset.** The moment you stop paying for ads, traffic falls to zero. Content keeps working. This is *The Apple Tree Rule*: it takes time to plant the seed and grow the tree, but once mature that single tree bears fruit for years without you having to buy the apples.

### 1.5.3 The Campaign Ecosystem — Hub and Spokes

A coherent digital campaign is not a list of disconnected activities. It is a hub-and-spoke system whose **hub is a quality company website** — the 24/7 portal and the ultimate conversion destination. Every other channel exists to feed it.

| Spoke                                            | Primary job                                                                |
|--------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Search Engine Optimisation (SEO)</b>          | Capture high-intent organic demand and drive it to the hub                 |
| <b>Search Engine Marketing / PPC</b>             | Buy immediate visibility on high-value commercial queries                  |
| <b>Social Media Marketing</b>                    | Manage global chatter, build awareness, and engineer community             |
| <b>Content Marketing / Blogging &amp; Forums</b> | Produce the compelling, genuine material every other channel distributes   |
| <b>E-mail Marketing</b>                          | Own the relationship; deliver personalised, rapid-response communication   |
| <b>Affiliate Marketing</b>                       | Pay partners only for results — traffic, leads or sales actually delivered |



| Spoke                         | Primary job                                                     |
|-------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|
| Display & Network Advertising | Build reach and remarket to prior visitors                      |
| Mobile Marketing              | Reach the customer on the device that is always with them       |
| Video Marketing               | Build trust and dwell time; dual search-and-social distribution |
| Local Listings                | Be discoverable in “near me” and map searches                   |
| Influencer Marketing          | Borrow trust that the brand has not yet earned                  |

### 1.5.4 Affiliate Marketing

#### EXAM ANSWER — asked in CIE-I, 3 April 2025 (2 marks)

**Affiliate marketing** is a type of **performance-based marketing** in which a business rewards **affiliates** (partners or individuals) for driving **traffic, leads or sales** to the company's products or services through the affiliate's own marketing efforts.

*Example:* Amazon Associates — a blogger places a tracked Amazon link in a product review and earns a commission on every purchase made through it.

- Payment models: **CPA** (cost per acquisition/sale), **CPL** (cost per lead), **CPC** (cost per click).
- Advantages: risk is transferred to the affiliate — you pay only for results; reach extends into audiences you do not own; costs are variable, not fixed.
- Risks: brand-safety issues if affiliates use aggressive or misleading tactics; potential for fraud; margin erosion if commissions are set too high.

### 1.5.5 Choosing Between Channels

CIE-I of 1.07.2024 asked students to choose between **SEO, PPC and Social Media Marketing** on a limited budget for a *high-tech gadget aimed at young professionals*. A strong answer compares them on a fixed set of criteria and then commits to a recommendation.

| Criterion        | SEO                                      | PPC (Pay Per Click)                           | Social Media Marketing                |
|------------------|------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------|
| Speed of results | Slow — months                            | Immediate                                     | Fast for reach, slow for trust        |
| Cost model       | Free per click; costs time and resources | Charged per click; stops when budget stops    | Organic free; paid boosts optional    |
| Longevity        | Infinite — compounds                     | Zero — ends with the campaign                 | Short (hours to days per post)        |
| Buyer intent     | High — the user is actively searching    | High — keyword-triggered                      | Low to medium — interruption-based    |
| Predictability   | High once established                    | High                                          | Low — relies on viral spikes          |
| Best suited to   | Long-term compounding demand             | Launches, promotions, high-margin conversions | Awareness, community, visual products |

**MODEL RECOMMENDATION**

For a **high-tech gadget aimed at young professionals** with a limited budget: allocate roughly **50% to PPC + paid social** for the launch window (the product is new, so no one is searching for it by name yet — organic search cannot deliver demand that does not yet exist); **30% to social media marketing**, especially Instagram, YouTube and LinkedIn, because young professionals discover technology through video reviews and peer validation; and **20% to SEO and content** — comparison articles, spec pages and “best gadget for X” content — as the compounding asset that reduces paid dependence over the following two quarters. Justify with the *intent* argument: PPC and social create the demand; SEO harvests it once it exists.

## 1.6 Tools to Create a Buyer Persona

The buyer persona is the single most repeated 10-mark question in this course — the adventure-tourism travel agency scenario appeared **verbatim in both CIE-I 2025 and CIE-I 2026**. Learn the process, the factors, and be ready to invent a named example persona.

### 1.6.1 What a Buyer Persona Is

#### DEFINITION

A **buyer persona** is a semi-fictional, research-based profile of your ideal customer — given a name, a face, a backstory and a set of goals, pain points and behaviours — built from real data about existing customers rather than from assumption.

**Rule: you cannot hit a target you haven't defined.** The ideal is **4 to 6 distinct personas** per business (for example Executive Sponsor, Decision Maker, End User).

### 1.6.2 The Five-Step Process (official CIE scheme)

1. **Research your current customers.** Analyse your best existing clients — those who buy often, leave reviews and engage with your content. Conduct surveys or interviews (online, or post-purchase/post-trip feedback forms).
2. **Segment your audience.** Divide customers into categories based on shared traits — for a travel agency, by travel habits, destination preferences and trip budgets.
3. **Gather data.** Use tools like **Google Analytics** and **social media insights** to identify patterns in who actually interacts with your website and social pages.
4. **Identify goals and pain points** — for example, the desire for adventure set against safety concerns.
5. **Build the persona.** Give it a name, a photo and a backstory to make it relatable — e.g. “*Adventurous Ananya*” or “*Explorer Ethan*” — and attach the key data points. Then **validate and update** it using continuing customer feedback and trend data.

### 1.6.3 Factors to Consider

| Category                                          | Factors to capture                                                             | Adventure-tourism illustration                                                                                                                 |
|---------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Demographics</b>                               | Age, gender, income level, occupation, education, location, family status      | 20–40 years; working professionals and students; income sufficient to afford travel; metro-based                                               |
| <b>Psychographics (interests &amp; lifestyle)</b> | Values, attitudes, hobbies, aspirations, risk appetite                         | Interest in trekking, scuba diving, skydiving; fitness and outdoor lifestyle; risk-taking attitude; prefers unique experiences over luxury     |
| <b>Online behaviour</b>                           | Platforms used, search patterns, content preference, device, booking behaviour | Instagram, YouTube and travel blogs; searches “best trekking places”; prefers videos, reels and reviews; books online packages via mobile apps |
| <b>Category behaviour</b>                         | Frequency, budget tier, group vs solo, preferred variants                      | Travels 2–3 times a year; budget vs premium; solo or small group; mountains, beaches, forests                                                  |
| <b>Goals</b>                                      | What success looks like for them                                               | Unique, thrilling, shareable experiences                                                                                                       |
| <b>Pain points</b>                                | What blocks the purchase                                                       | Safety concerns, budget constraints, lack of reliable information, distrust of agencies                                                        |
| <b>Objections</b>                                 | What they say when they say no                                                 | “Is it safe?” “Is the guide certified?” “What if I have to cancel?”                                                                            |

### 1.6.4 The Persona Builder Canvas — Four Quadrants

| Quadrant                      | Questions to answer                                                                                      |
|-------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1. Background & Goals         | What are their business goals and challenges? What is their team structure and job role?                 |
| 2. Information Sources        | Where do they consume content? Which social channels do they actively use — and which do they avoid?     |
| 3. Messaging & Topics         | Which marketing messages speak to them? What content topics capture their interest?                      |
| 4. Purchase Role & Objections | How much influence do they have in the decision? What objections do they raise during the sales process? |

### 1.6.5 A Worked Example Persona

#### PERSONA: “ADVENTURE ARUN”

**Name:** Adventure Arun · **Age:** 28 · **Occupation:** IT professional, Bengaluru

**Interests:** Trekking, camping, weekend rides

**Behaviour:** Follows travel influencers on Instagram and YouTube; researches on travel blogs; books entirely online, usually on mobile, usually 3–4 weeks ahead

**Goal:** Unique, thrilling experiences he can share

**Pain points:** Safety and affordability; not knowing whether the operator is credible

**What wins him:** Certified-guide credentials, real customer video testimonials, transparent inclusions, easy cancellation, EMI options

### 1.6.6 Tools

| Category                         | Tools                                                                                                     | What they give you                                                                                        |
|----------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Analytics                        | Google Analytics 4, Google Search Console                                                                 | Demographics, interests, devices, locations, acquisition channels, on-site behaviour                      |
| Social insights                  | Meta/Facebook Audience Insights, Instagram Insights, LinkedIn Page Analytics, X Analytics, YouTube Studio | Follower demographics, active hours, content resonance                                                    |
| Survey & voice-of-customer       | Google Forms, Typeform, SurveyMonkey, Hotjar polls, post-purchase feedback forms                          | Stated goals, objections and satisfaction                                                                 |
| Persona builders                 | HubSpot Make My Persona, Xtensio, Userforge, Semrush Persona                                              | A structured template and shareable persona document                                                      |
| Behavioural / qualitative mining | Quora, Reddit, Amazon reviews, YouTube comments, competitor review sections                               | The exact behavioural problems and questions the audience is actively trying to solve, in their own words |
| CRM & sales data                 | HubSpot, Zoho, Salesforce, sales-call notes                                                               | Real objections, deal-cycle length, decision roles                                                        |

#### THE DEMOGRAPHICS / PSYCHOGRAPHICS SPLIT

Use **Google Analytics** and **Facebook Insights** for **hard data** on age, location and income. Use **Quora**, **Reddit** and **Amazon reviews** to **extract the exact behavioural problems** — the pain points, common questions, motivations, desired outcomes, objections and influences — that your audience is actively trying to solve. Hard data tells you *who*; social listening tells you *why*.

## 1.7 Competitor Research Tools

“Know the competition” is the second pillar of digital strategy. Competition online can come from around the corner or around the globe, so the analysis must never be limited to local rivals.

### 1.7.1 What to Look For

- Which **keywords** they rank for organically, and which they pay for.
- Their **backlink profile** — who links to them and why.
- Their **content gaps** — topics with demand that nobody has covered well. This is where opportunity lives.
- Their **traffic sources and volume**, and how these are trending.
- Their **social share of voice** — conversations about them versus conversations about you.
- Their **ad creatives, offers and landing pages**.
- Their **pricing, positioning and value proposition**.

### 1.7.2 The Toolset

| Tool                                                             | Primary use                                                                                                                  |
|------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| SEMrush                                                          | All-round competitive intelligence — organic and paid keywords, traffic estimates, ad copy, backlink gap, Keyword Magic Tool |
| Ahrefs                                                           | Backlink analysis (the deepest link index), Content Gap and Top Pages reports                                                |
| Moz / Link Explorer                                              | Domain Authority and Page Authority scoring, link metrics                                                                    |
| SimilarWeb                                                       | Traffic estimates, traffic sources, audience overlap, referral analysis                                                      |
| SpyFu                                                            | Historical competitor PPC keyword and ad-spend data                                                                          |
| BuzzSumo                                                         | Which content in a topic earned the most shares and backlinks — content-gap discovery                                        |
| Google Trends                                                    | Relative search interest over time, seasonality, regional variation, rising queries                                          |
| Google Keyword Planner                                           | Search volume and competition data straight from the ad platform                                                             |
| Meta Ad Library / Google Ads Transparency Center                 | The competitor's <i>live</i> ad creatives, free of charge                                                                    |
| Social listening — Hootsuite, Brandwatch, Mention, Sprout Social | Share of voice, sentiment, brand mention tracking                                                                            |

## 1.8 Website Analysis Tools

The SEE of June/July 2025 asked (Q2a, compulsory): “Discuss how website analysis contributes to enhanced customer experience and conversion optimization.” Website analysis has two halves — **technical health** and **behavioural insight**.

| Tool                  | What it analyses                                                                               |
|-----------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Google Analytics 4    | Sessions, users, acquisition channels, engagement, conversions, funnels, audience demographics |
| Google Search Console | Impressions, clicks, average position, indexing status, Core Web Vitals, crawl errors          |

| Tool                                   | What it analyses                                                                         |
|----------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Google PageSpeed Insights / Lighthouse | Load speed, Core Web Vitals (LCP, INP, CLS), accessibility, SEO and best-practice audits |
| GTmetrix / Pingdom                     | Page load waterfall, asset weight, server response time                                  |
| Hotjar / Microsoft Clarity / Crazy Egg | Heatmaps, scroll maps, click maps and <b>session recordings</b> — what users actually do |
| Screaming Frog SEO Spider              | Full technical crawl — broken links, duplicate titles, redirect chains, missing meta     |
| SEMrush Site Audit / Ahrefs Site Audit | Automated technical SEO health score and prioritised issue list                          |
| Google Optimize / VWO / Optimizely     | <b>A/B testing</b> and multivariate testing of pages and elements                        |
| Google Tag Manager                     | Central deployment and management of all tracking tags without touching code             |
| W3C Validator / WAVE                   | Code validity and accessibility conformance                                              |

### ***How website analysis improves customer experience and conversion***

1. **Diagnoses friction.** Heatmaps and session recordings expose where users hesitate, rage-click or abandon.
2. **Fixes speed.** Slow pages are the single largest cause of abandonment; speed audits convert directly into retained sessions.
3. **Reveals the drop-off point in the funnel.** Funnel reports show *which* step loses people, so the fix is targeted rather than cosmetic.
4. **Validates changes objectively** through A/B testing instead of opinion.
5. **Segments experience by device and channel**, exposing (for instance) a mobile-only checkout bug.
6. **Aligns content with intent** by showing which pages attract traffic that never converts — the classic “traffic without intent” problem.

## 1.9 Content Marketing — Concepts and Strategies

### 1.9.1 Definition and the Core Idea

#### DEFINITION

**Content marketing** is a strategic marketing approach focused on creating and distributing valuable, relevant and consistent content to attract and retain a clearly defined audience — and, ultimately, to drive profitable customer action.

The governing principle: **don't sell the product; solve the problem.** Great content integrates your product into the customer's natural pursuit of their own passions.

### 1.9.2 A Century of Proof — Content Marketing Is Not New

| Year  | Example                   | Strategy                                                                                     |
|-------|---------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1895  | John Deere's "The Furrow" | Educate the farmer — a magazine about farming, not about tractors                            |
| 1900  | The Michelin Guide        | Inspire the driver to travel farther for a three-star meal, creating the need for more tyres |
| 1930s | Soap operas               | Entertain the homemaker with radio dramas sponsored by soap companies                        |

#### THE BLUEPRINT SYNTHESIS

**The medium changes. The strategy doesn't.** Michelin did not advertise tyres; it made driving further desirable. John Deere did not advertise ploughs; it made farmers better at farming. That is still exactly what content marketing does.

### 1.9.3 The Compounding Traffic Curve

Paid advertising produces a sawtooth: spend, spike, stop, collapse. Content produces a curve that starts slower and then rises continuously, because each asset keeps earning traffic long after it is published, and new assets stack on top of old ones.

#### THE APPLE TREE RULE

It takes time to plant the seed and grow the tree. But once mature, that single tree continually bears fruit for years — without requiring you to buy the apples. Advertising is a **rented treadmill**; content is an **owned asset**.

### 1.9.4 The Five Traits of Elite Content Marketers

1. **Documented strategy** — they operate from a written plan, not intuition.
2. **Dedicated leadership** — a specific named person is assigned to oversee the content engine.
3. **Expanded tactics** — they use a wider variety of content formats than their peers.
4. **Multi-platform distribution** — they leverage more channels than their peers.
5. **Budget allocation** — they commit a higher percentage of the total marketing budget to content.

### 1.9.5 Characteristics of Good Content — The 7-Point Quality Gate

This is a guaranteed 2-mark question. It has appeared in **CIE-I 2025, CIE-I 2026 and the SEE of June/July 2025**. Two slightly different lists are accepted; learn the first, and know the second.

| Trait                | The diagnostic question                                |
|----------------------|--------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Credible</b>      | Will they believe it?                                  |
| <b>Shareable</b>     | Will the audience want to share it?                    |
| <b>Useful or fun</b> | Does it provide genuine utility or entertainment?      |
| <b>Interesting</b>   | Does it break through apathy? (necessarily subjective) |
| <b>Relevant</b>      | Does it connect to their current context?              |
| <b>Different</b>     | Does it stand out from the noise?                      |
| <b>On-brand</b>      | Is it authentically aligned with our identity?         |

### THE SECOND ACCEPTED LIST

The CIE-I 2026 scheme of valuation accepted any four of: **relevant, accurate, engaging, clear, consistent, valuable**. If the question says “mention any four”, either list scores full marks — but the seven-point gate above is the one taught in the lecture notes.



## 1.10 The Content Marketing Process — Eight Steps, Three Phases

The official CIE-I scheme of valuation answers the “step-by-step content marketing strategy” question with exactly this sequence. Memorise the eight step names in order; every scenario question in this course is answered by walking through them.

### THE EIGHT STEPS (official scheme answer)

**1. Goal Setting → 2. Audience Mapping → 3. Content Ideation and Planning → 4. Content Creation → 5. Content Distribution → 6. Content Amplification → 7. Content Marketing Evaluation → 8. Content Marketing Improvement**

— and then back to step 1. It is a **cycle**, not a checklist.

| Phase                         | Steps                                               | Purpose                                                   |
|-------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Phase 1 — Architecture</b> | Goal Setting, Audience Mapping, Ideation & Planning | Decide <i>why</i> , <i>for whom</i> , and <i>what</i>     |
| <b>Phase 2 — Mechanics</b>    | Creation, Distribution, Amplification               | Actually build it and get it in front of people           |
| <b>Phase 3 — Telemetry</b>    | Evaluation, Improvement                             | Find out whether it worked and make the next cycle better |

### 1.10.1 Step 1 — Goal Setting

The primary objective always splits into two branches, and every subsequent decision inherits from this split.

- **Brand-building objective** — awareness, recall, reputation, authority, share of voice.
- **Sales-growth objective** — leads, conversions, revenue, repeat purchase.

Three reflective questions found the goal:

1. What is the content that you think will be valuable to your company?
2. How can the content tell a story about your brand?
3. How do you plan to execute your content marketing strategy?

### CIE-I 2026 PART A

“What is the first step of content marketing?” — the official answer is **define goals / identify the target audience**. Do not answer “create content”.

### 1.10.2 Step 2 — Audience Mapping

Audience mapping is built **outward from internal psychology**, not inward from demographics. The order matters.

1. **Anxieties and desires** — the psychological foundation at the core.
2. **Pain points** — how those anxieties manifest as real-world problems.
3. **Customer profiling and persona** — the visible marketing artefact, built on the two inner layers.

Most failed content strategies invert this, starting with a demographic and never reaching the anxiety. See §1.6 for the full persona method.

### 1.10.3 Step 3 — Content Ideation and Planning

Ideation must be constrained by a disciplined roadmap, or it degenerates into random posting. Four layers produce the plan.

| Layer                   | Output                                                                               |
|-------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Strategic layer</b>  | The <b>content theme</b> — the territory the brand will own                          |
| <b>Structural layer</b> | The <b>content formats and mix</b> — which media, in what ratio                      |
| <b>Temporal layer</b>   | The <b>storyline and calendar</b> — what publishes when, and in what narrative order |
| <b>Result</b>           | The <b>Content Road Map</b>                                                          |

#### 1.10.4 Step 4 — Content Creation

The pivot question is *who creates the content, and when?* Two resource branches feed a single **content production schedule**: **in-house creators** and **external agencies**. In-house wins on brand authenticity and subject knowledge; agencies win on capacity, production quality and speed.

##### *Aligning format to funnel stage*

| Stage                           | Formats                                  | KPI                      |
|---------------------------------|------------------------------------------|--------------------------|
| <b>Awareness</b>                | Infographics, social videos, podcasts    | Reach & shares           |
| <b>Engagement</b>               | How-to blogs, YouTube tutorials          | Dwell time & video views |
| <b>Evaluation</b>               | Case studies, e-books, whitepapers       | Leads & downloads        |
| <b>Purchase &amp; Retention</b> | Newsletters, native ads, product updates | Conversion & open rates  |

##### *Anatomy of a top-ranking page*

- **H1 title** — click-worthy, exact-match keyword headline.
- **Introduction** — comprehensive, answering the user's core intent immediately.
- **Structure** — H2/H3 subheadings containing LSI (long-tail) keyword variants.
- **Formatting** — short, scannable paragraphs and bulleted lists.
- **Rich media** — embedded videos and infographics to increase dwell time.
- **Architecture** — internal links to keep users in your ecosystem, plus credible outbound links to build trust.

#### 1.10.5 Step 5 — Content Distribution

Distribution runs on the **owned – paid – earned trinity** (§1.5.2). Choose the mix using the distribution ecosystem matrix below.

| Channel             | Predictability | Lifespan      | Core characteristics                                   |
|---------------------|----------------|---------------|--------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Google SEO</b>   | High           | Infinite      | High buyer intent, search-driven                       |
| <b>YouTube</b>      | Medium         | Long          | Dual search-and-social algorithm; massive visual trust |
| <b>Social media</b> | Low            | Short (hours) | Flatlining traffic curve; relies on viral spikes       |
| <b>E-mail</b>       | High           | Medium        | Direct ownership; highest conversion and retention     |

#### 1.10.6 Step 6 — Content Amplification

Amplification creates compounding momentum by activating network effects. The central question is: *how do you plan to leverage content assets and interact with customers?* Three nodes answer it.

1. **Creating communities** — owned groups, forums and user communities that redistribute content for you.
2. **Use of buzzers** — employees, partners and enthusiasts who seed and share content early.
3. **Use of influencers** — borrowing the trust of established opinion leaders (§1.4.5).

### 1.10.7 Mapping Content to the 5A Customer Path

| Stage    | What the content must be                                        |
|----------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|
| Aware    | <b>Visible</b> — it must be found where attention already is    |
| Appeal   | <b>Relatable</b> — it must feel like it is about them           |
| Ask      | <b>Searchable</b> — it must answer the questions they type      |
| Act      | <b>Actionable</b> — it must make the next step obvious and easy |
| Advocate | <b>Shareable</b> — it must be worth passing on                  |

#### *The content-driven customer journey — a worked example*

| Stage              | What the customer thinks     | What they consume                       |
|--------------------|------------------------------|-----------------------------------------|
| Problem aware      | "Kids need to climb inside." | Searches "best home climbing equipment" |
| Solution research  | "Mini jungle gyms exist."    | Reads a "Top 10 jungle gyms" blog post  |
| Product evaluation | "Will my oldest fit?"        | Watches a YouTube product review        |
| Purchase           | "This model works."          | Reads Amazon reviews and buys           |

#### THE ARCHITECT'S NOTE

You must intentionally integrate your brand at **every stepping stone**. If your content isn't there, a competitor's will be.

### 1.10.8 Steps 7 and 8 — Evaluation and Improvement

The evaluation question is: *how successful is your content marketing campaign?* It is answered through two measurement protocols — (i) tracking specific content-marketing metrics (KPIs such as traffic, engagement rate, lead generation and conversion tied to individual assets), and (ii) determining overall objective achievement (the holistic impact on brand awareness, reputation and revenue), which loops back to the brand-building and sales-growth goals set in Step 1.

Improvement then pulls on exactly two levers:

- **Lever 1 — Content theme change and improvement** (adjusting the *architecture*).
- **Lever 2 — Distribution and amplification improvement** (adjusting the *mechanics*).

#### *The continuous optimisation loop*

- **A/B testing** — continuously run split tests on headline variants, CTA tone, image choices and content length.
- **Historical audits** — regularly update older high-ranking content with fresh data, new internal links and current examples to protect existing traffic.

**THE COMPLETE CONTENT FLYWHEEL**

**Audience Research → Keyword Strategy → Content Creation → Multi-Channel Distribution → Meaningful Measurement** → (back to Audience Research). Each phase powers the next, and measurement optimises the subsequent cycle. The centre of the wheel is **unstoppable compounding revenue growth**.  
*Content is never finished. It is an asset that requires continuous maintenance.*

## 1.11 Optimising Website UX and Landing Pages

Traffic that arrives at a badly designed page is wasted money. This section is also directly examinable in Unit IV and Unit V; treat it as shared ground.

### 1.11.1 Krug's First Law of Usability

#### “DON'T MAKE ME THINK.”

A person of average — or below average — ability must be able to work out how to accomplish a task on your page. It must be **self-evident** and **self-explanatory**. The good news: usability isn't rocket science.

### 1.11.2 The Seven Usability Attributes

| Attribute  | Test question                                 |
|------------|-----------------------------------------------|
| Useful     | Does it do what people actually need?         |
| Learnable  | Can they figure it out?                       |
| Memorable  | Do they have to relearn it every visit?       |
| Effective  | Does it get the job done?                     |
| Efficient  | Does it do so in a reasonable amount of time? |
| Desirable  | Do people <i>want</i> it?                     |
| Delightful | Is it enjoyable to use?                       |

### 1.11.3 How People Actually Use the Web

There is a gap between how we *think* people use websites — carefully reading instructions like a novel — and how they actually do: **scanning, satisficing and muddling through**. “Satisficing” means choosing the first option that plausibly works rather than the best one.

Why don't people read instructions? Three reasons:

1. It isn't important to them — they just want it to work.
2. They are on a mission and know they don't need to read everything.
3. If they find something that works, they stick to it rather than looking for a better way.

### 1.11.4 Billboard Design 101 — Design for Scanning, Not Reading

- **Follow visual hierarchy** — make important elements visually prominent, in proportion to their importance.
- **Omit needless words** — the art of not writing for the web. Happy talk must die; instructions must die.
- **Make clickables obvious** — it must be instantly clear what can be clicked. Competition is one click away, and ambiguity produces frustration.
- **Provide breadcrumbs and street signs** — clear, conventional, intuitive navigation so the user always knows where they are.

### 1.11.5 Landing Page Essentials

- **One page, one job.** A landing page with two goals achieves neither.

- **A headline that matches the ad** that brought the visitor there — message match is the largest single lever on conversion rate.
- **A clear, prominent, single call to action**, repeated above and below the fold.
- **Benefit-led copy**, not feature-led — what the visitor gets, not what the product has.
- **Trust signals** — testimonials, ratings, certifications, guarantees, secure-payment badges, real photographs.
- **Minimal form friction** — every additional field reduces completion; ask only for what you will actually use.
- **Fast load and mobile responsiveness** — non-negotiable.
- **Remove navigation and exits** on a dedicated campaign landing page so the only way forward is the CTA.

## 1.12 Measuring Impact — Metrics and Performance

CIE-I of 1.07.2024 asked: “Identify and explain at least five key metrics used to measure the impact and performance of content marketing efforts. How can these metrics influence future content strategies?” Organise the answer into the three diagnostic buckets below — a list of metrics without a structure scores poorly.

### 1.12.1 The Three Diagnostic Buckets

| Bucket                           | Metrics                                                                        | What it diagnoses                                                  |
|----------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Reach &amp; Visibility</b>    | Impressions, unique viewers, reach, new users, backlinks earned                | Top-of-funnel <i>scale</i> — are we being seen at all?             |
| <b>Resonance &amp; Memory</b>    | Brand recall, brand mentions, sentiment, share of voice, direct traffic growth | Lasting <i>psychological impact</i> — are we remembered?           |
| <b>Engagement &amp; Friction</b> | Bounce rate, time on site, pages per session, scroll depth, shares, comments   | Content <i>quality</i> and user interaction — is it actually good? |

### 1.12.2 The Five Metrics to Name in the Exam

1. **Website traffic / unique visitors** — measures whether content is attracting an audience. *Influence on strategy*: rising traffic on a theme signals which topics to double down on.
2. **Engagement rate** (time on page, scroll depth, pages per session, likes, shares, comments) — measures whether the content held attention. *Influence*: a high-traffic, low-engagement page signals a headline that over-promises.
3. **Bounce rate** — the percentage of visitors who leave after viewing only one page without interaction. *Influence*: high bounce on a converting keyword points to a message-match or speed problem.
4. **Lead generation** (form submissions, sign-ups, downloads) — measures whether content converts attention into a contactable relationship. *Influence*: identifies which assets deserve gated versions and paid promotion.
5. **Conversion rate and ROI** — the percentage completing the desired action, and revenue attributable to content versus cost. *Influence*: determines budget allocation for the next cycle.

Additional metrics worth naming: organic search ranking, keyword coverage, backlinks earned, email open and click-through rates, customer retention and repeat purchase rate, and cost per lead.

### 1.12.3 Align the Metric to the Medium

### THE MEASUREMENT RULE

**Align the metric to the medium.** Measuring an e-book by pageviews is a recipe for failure.

**Video** → audience retention and total watch time. **Blog & SEO** → organic rank and dwell time. **Lead magnets** → download volume and lead conversion rate. **E-mail** → open rate and click-through rate.

### 1.12.4 Aligning KPIs to Organisational Goals

This was a 10-mark CIE-I 2026 question. The five-step answer:

1. **Identify business goals** — define clear objectives (increase sales, brand awareness, lead generation).
2. **Map goals to relevant KPIs** — Sales growth → conversion rate, revenue, cart-abandonment rate. Brand awareness → traffic, impressions, reach. Lead generation → form submissions, sign-ups. Customer engagement → bounce rate, session duration, pages per visit.
3. **Make KPIs SMART** — Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Relevant, Time-bound (e.g. *increase conversion rate by 10% in 3 months*).
4. **Use analytics tools** — track through Google Analytics and dashboards.
5. **Monitor and optimise continuously** — analyse regularly and modify strategy based on performance.

## 1.13 Using Content Research for Opportunities

The SEE of June/July 2025 asked (Q2b, compulsory): “*Explain how content research tools help marketers discover new opportunities and gain a competitive edge.*”

### 1.13.1 Finding the Keyword Sweet Spot

A topic is worth pursuing only where three circles overlap.

- **High search volume** — a minimum of roughly 250–1,000+ monthly searches.
- **Low SEO difficulty** — under about a 40 SD/KD score, so you can realistically rank.
- **Commercial intent** — high cost-per-click and buyer-specific phrasing, indicating the searcher intends to purchase.

### WARNING

**Traffic without intent is useless. Do not optimise for clicks; optimise for revenue.** A page ranking first for a query no buyer ever types is a vanity asset.

### 1.13.2 How Content Research Creates Competitive Edge

1. **Reveals demand that already exists** — keyword and question research shows what the market is actively asking, removing guesswork.
2. **Exposes content gaps** — topics with volume where competitors rank poorly or not at all. This is the fastest route to visibility.
3. **Identifies trends early** — Google Trends and social listening surface rising topics before they saturate, allowing first-mover advantage.
4. **Benchmarks the competition** — shows what already works in the niche so effort is spent on proven formats rather than experiments.
5. **Improves ROI** — resources go to topics with demonstrated demand and achievable difficulty instead of being spread evenly.

6. **Supplies the customer's own language** — mining Quora, Reddit and reviews yields the exact phrasing to use in headlines and copy.
7. **Feeds every other channel** — one research pass supplies the SEO plan, the social calendar, the e-mail themes and the ad copy.

### 1.13.3 Content Research Toolset

- **Keyword research** — Google Keyword Planner, SEMrush Keyword Magic Tool, Ahrefs Keywords Explorer, Ubersuggest.
- **Question mining** — AnswerThePublic, AlsoAsked, Google's "People Also Ask" and "Related searches".
- **Trend detection** — Google Trends, Exploding Topics, X/Twitter trending topics.
- **Content performance** — BuzzSumo (most-shared and most-linked content in any topic), Ahrefs Content Explorer.
- **Audience listening** — Quora, Reddit, niche forums, Amazon and app-store reviews, YouTube comments.
- **Gap analysis** — SEMrush Keyword Gap, Ahrefs Content Gap.



## 1.14 Supporting Concept — The Product Life Cycle

The PLC underpins several content and channel decisions and appears in the supplementary lecture material. Every product follows a natural, largely inevitable path from launch to eventual disappearance; mastering that timeline is a key to sustained profitability.

### 1.14.1 Diagnosing the Stage

- **Market volatility** — are rapid industry shifts limiting the product's lifespan or favouring new, improved alternatives?
- **Consumer behaviour** — is the product an everyday necessity? Does it solve a common problem? Is its usage simple or complex?
- **Competitive landscape** — how easily can competitors replicate it? Map the number of rivals, their expertise, pricing and distribution channels.

### 1.14.2 The Master Lifecycle Matrix

|                           | Introduction                       | Growth                       | Maturity                          | Decline                   |
|---------------------------|------------------------------------|------------------------------|-----------------------------------|---------------------------|
| <b>Sales volume</b>       | Low                                | Surging                      | Stabilising                       | Dropping                  |
| <b>Competition</b>        | Non-existent                       | Increasing                   | Entrenched                        | Dominating                |
| <b>Primary goal</b>       | Create awareness & generate demand | Build market share & loyalty | Defend position & maximise profit | Minimise losses           |
| <b>Core strategy</b>      | Promos & demos                     | Customisation & expansion    | Diversification & cross-selling   | Niche focus & liquidation |
| <b>Historical example</b> | Apple iPhone (2007)                | Zara (1990s–2000s)           | Kellogg's                         | Kodak (1990s–2012)        |

#### Stage tactics

- **Introduction** — consumers are unfamiliar; demand is low while production and distribution costs are high. Offer targeted promotions, discounts and free samples; host product demonstrations to prove functional value; deploy influencer marketing for immediate social proof; use mass media advertising; create shareable brand experiences. *Apple, 2007*: massive TV advertising plus a limited initial release and heavily promoted exclusivity generated unprecedented demand.
- **Growth** — sales and profits surge as competitors flood the market. Introduce product customisation; deliver exceptional customer service to lock in loyalty; identify new segments and expand geographically. *Zara*: rapid international expansion while producing small quantities of exclusive designs, creating permanent novelty.
- **Maturity** — the longest stage; growth slows, competitors are entrenched and prices fall. Diversify product lines; drive cross-selling with complementary goods; innovate continuously through formula or feature updates; deploy value-based content marketing; compete on cost by optimising production and sourcing. *Kellogg's*: competitor-comparison ads, organic lines, and cereal bundled with dried fruit and snack bars.
- **Decline** — demand drops as technology or trends shift. Focus on a smaller, highly profitable niche; reposition the brand for new segments; cut marketing spend and rely on organic channels; implement deep cost reductions and discounting; execute exit strategies. *Kodak*: cut prices, diversified into digital printing and sold patents, yet still filed for bankruptcy — proving some technological shifts are irreversible.

### 1.14.3 The Lifecycle Is Not Always Linear

- **Short life (A)** — fad products that spike and die without ever reaching maturity.
- **Extended life (B)** — core staples that plateau and dominate profitably for decades.
- **The pivot (C)** — products that reset their own curve through radical repositioning or new-market expansion.

## 1.15 Key Terms — Quick Revision

| Term                               | One-line meaning                                                                              |
|------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Digital marketing</b>           | Targeted, conversion-oriented, quantifiable, interactive marketing using digital technologies |
| <b>Marketplace / Market space</b>  | Physical location of exchange / virtual environment where value is created digitally          |
| <b>Push / Pull marketing</b>       | Brand pushes product to customer / customer actively seeks the brand                          |
| <b>Mantra of marketing</b>         | Create, Communicate, Deliver, Value, Target, Profit                                           |
| <b>Needs / Wants / Demands</b>     | Basic requirement / need aimed at a specific object / want backed by ability to pay           |
| <b>Value proposition</b>           | The set of benefits a firm offers to satisfy a customer need                                  |
| <b>Buyer persona</b>               | Research-based semi-fictional profile of the ideal customer                                   |
| <b>Owned / Paid / Earned media</b> | Assets you control / reach you buy / reach the audience gives you                             |
| <b>Content marketing</b>           | Creating and distributing valuable, relevant, consistent content to drive profitable action   |
| <b>4-1-1 rule</b>                  | 4 educational posts + 1 soft promo + 1 hard promo (see Unit II)                               |
| <b>Affiliate marketing</b>         | Performance-based marketing paying partners for traffic, leads or sales                       |
| <b>Bounce rate</b>                 | % of visitors who leave after viewing only one page without interaction                       |
| <b>Landing page</b>                | A single-purpose page a campaign sends traffic to, built for one conversion                   |
| <b>CTA (Call to Action)</b>        | The explicit instruction telling the visitor what to do next                                  |
| <b>Influencer</b>                  | An early-adopter online opinion leader who holds the virtual ear of the masses                |
| <b>Prosumer</b>                    | A consumer who also shapes or produces what they consume                                      |
| <b>PLC</b>                         | Product Life Cycle — Introduction, Growth, Maturity, Decline                                  |

## 1.16 Previous Year Questions — Unit I

Every question below is reproduced from an actual RVCE Marketing Management CIE or SEE paper. Answers and pointers follow the official schemes of valuation where these were released.

### A. Two-Mark Questions (Part A)

**1. Differentiate between marketplace and market space. [CIE-I 3 Apr 2025; CIE-I 16 Apr 2026]**

**Marketplace** — a physical or digital location where buyers and sellers come together to exchange goods and services (a mall, a showroom). **Market space** — a conceptual or virtual environment where commercial value is created through digital networks and communication technologies (Amazon, an app). Shorthand: marketplace = physical; market space = digital/online.

**2. What is the mantra of marketing? [CIE-I 3 Apr 2025]**

Create, Communicate, Deliver, Value, Target, Profit.

**3. Define affiliate marketing and give an example. [CIE-I 3 Apr 2025]**

A performance-based marketing model in which a business rewards affiliates — partners or individuals — for driving traffic, leads or sales to its products or services through the affiliate's own marketing efforts. *Example:* Amazon Associates, where a blogger earns commission on purchases made via a tracked link.

**4. Mention any four characteristics of a good content. [CIE-I 3 Apr 2025; CIE-I 16 Apr 2026; SEE Jun/Jul 2025]**

Any four of: **credible, shareable, useful, interesting, relevant, different, on-brand.** (The 2026 scheme also accepts: relevant, accurate, engaging, clear, consistent, valuable.)

**5. Differentiate between push and pull marketing. [CIE-I 3 Apr 2025; CIE-I 16 Apr 2026; SEE Jun/Jul 2025]**

**Push** — the brand promotes products by pushing them towards the customer (TV ads, dealer incentives, direct selling). **Pull** — the brand encourages customers to actively seek out the product (SEO, content, word of mouth).

**6. What is the first step of content marketing? [CIE-I 16 Apr 2026]**

Define goals / identify the target audience.

**7. Mention any two core concepts of marketing. [CIE-I 16 Apr 2026]**

Any two of: needs, wants, demand, value, exchange, markets.

**8. List any 2 principles of digital marketing. [SEE Oct/Nov 2023]**

Any two of the five pillars — know your business; know the competition; know your customers; know what you want to achieve (measurable goals); know how you're doing (measurement and iteration). Alternatively: measurability, interactivity, personalisation, permission-based targeting.

**9. Differentiate between market segmentation and market mix. [SEE Oct/Nov 2023]**

**Market segmentation** is the process of dividing a heterogeneous total market into smaller homogeneous groups of buyers with similar needs, on bases such as geographic, demographic, psychographic and behavioural, so that each can be targeted distinctly. **Marketing mix** is the set of controllable tactical tools — Product, Price, Place and Promotion (the 4 Ps) — that the firm blends to produce the response it wants from its chosen target segment. In short: segmentation decides *whom* to serve; the marketing mix decides *how* to serve them.

### B. Ten-Mark and Eight-Mark Questions (Part B)

**1. A newly launched e-commerce company wants to build brand awareness through content marketing. Suggest a step-by-step strategy for them, including content types and distribution channels. [CIE-I 3 Apr 2025, 10 marks]**

**Official scheme answer — the eight steps:** Goal setting → audience mapping → content ideation and planning → content creation → content distribution → content amplification → content marketing evaluation → content marketing improvement. Expand each with the detail in §1.10, naming content types (blogs, videos, infographics, podcasts, e-books, UGC) and distribution across owned, earned and paid media.

**2. A newly launched health & wellness startup offering organic lifestyle products aims to build strong brand awareness through content marketing. Design a step-by-step content marketing strategy, clearly outlining: content formats; content themes; distribution platforms (owned, earned, paid media); metrics for performance evaluation. [CIE-I 16 Apr 2026, 10 marks]**

**1. Objectives** — build brand awareness; educate customers on organic lifestyle; generate leads and conversions.

- **2. Content themes** — organic living and its benefits; health and nutrition; sustainability and eco-friendly practices; product awareness; customer testimonials and expert advice.
- **3. Content formats** — blogs and articles (SEO); videos and reels (workouts, product demos); infographics (diet charts); podcasts (wellness talks); e-books and webinars; user-generated content (reviews).
- **4. Distribution platforms** — *Owned media*: website, blog, e-mail. *Earned media*: social media shares, influencer mentions, PR. *Paid media*: social media ads, Google Ads, influencer promotions.
- **5. Metrics for evaluation** — *Awareness*: reach, impressions, website traffic. *Engagement*: likes, shares, comments, watch time. *Leads*: sign-ups, downloads. *Conversions*: sales, conversion rate. *Retention*: repeat customers, loyalty.

**3. A travel agency specializing in adventure tourism wants to improve its targeted marketing. How should they create a buyer persona, and what factors (e.g., demographics, interests, online behaviour) should they consider? [CIE-I 3 Apr 2025 AND CIE-I 16 Apr 2026, 10 marks]**

Answer in three parts. **(i) Steps to create the persona**: collect data (surveys, website analytics, social media insights); segment the audience by shared traits; identify goals and pain points; build the persona profile with a name, background and behaviour details; validate and update using feedback and trends. **(ii) Factors**: demographics (age 20–40, gender, income, occupation, location); psychographics (interest in trekking/scuba/skydiving, fitness and outdoor lifestyle, risk-taking attitude, preference for unique experiences over luxury); online behaviour (Instagram, YouTube, travel blogs; searches like “best trekking places”; prefers videos and reviews; books online via mobile apps); travel behaviour (frequency, budget vs premium, group vs solo, preferred destinations); pain points (safety concerns, budget constraints, lack of information, trust in agencies). **(iii) Example persona**: *Adventure Arun* — age 28, IT professional; interests trekking and camping; follows travel influencers and books online; goal is unique thrilling experiences; pain point is safety and affordability. See §1.6 for the full treatment.

**4. A retail company has been using traditional marketing methods such as newspaper ads, billboards, and TV commercials. However, they are now considering a shift to digital marketing. Compare the benefits and limitations of both approaches and suggest a strategy for transitioning to digital marketing. [CIE-I 3 Apr 2025 AND 16 Apr 2026, 10 marks]**

**Traditional — benefits**: wide reach (TV, newspapers); high credibility and trust; effective for a mass audience. **Limitations**: expensive; difficult to measure results; no precise targeting; one-way communication. **Digital — benefits**: cost-effective; targeted advertising by age, location and interests; measurable results through analytics and ROI; two-way interaction; global reach. **Limitations**: requires

technical skills; high online competition; privacy concerns; dependent on internet access. **Transition strategy:** start with a hybrid approach; build website and social presence; use SEO and content marketing; run targeted ads; leverage e-mail marketing and influencers; track performance with analytics; gradually reduce traditional spending based on results. Support with the comparison table in §1.1.3.

**5. Identify and explain the various entities that can be marketed, providing relevant examples for each category. [CIE-I 3 Apr 2025, 10 marks]**

The ten entities — **goods, services, experiences, events, persons, places, properties, organizations, information and ideas** — each explained with an example. Use the table in §1.0.5.

**6. How have the 4Ps of marketing (Product, Price, Place, and Promotion) evolved in the digital era? Provide examples of companies effectively leveraging digital strategies for each element. [CIE-I 3 Apr 2025, 10 marks]**

**Product** → **digital and personalised products** (Spotify's data-driven personalised playlists). **Price** → **dynamic and transparent pricing** (Amazon's AI-driven price adjustment by demand, competition and user behaviour). **Place** → **online channels and omnichannel presence** (Nike's seamless website, app and store experience with click-and-collect). **Promotion** → **digital and interactive marketing** (Coca-Cola's "Share a Coke" social campaign). See §1.0.12.

**7. Describe the key principles of digital marketing and explain how they differ from traditional marketing approaches. Provide examples to illustrate your points. [CIE-I 1 Jul 2024, 10 marks]**

State the five pillars (§1.2.1), add measurability, interactivity, personalisation, permission and iteration, then contrast each against traditional marketing using the comparison table in §1.1.3, with one concrete example per point.

**8. Your company has a limited marketing budget and needs to choose between Search Engine Optimization, Pay Per Click, and Social Media Marketing to promote a new product. Based on the product being a high-tech gadget aimed at young professionals, which channel(s) would you prioritize and why? Justify your decision with specific examples. [CIE-I 1 Jul 2024, 10 marks]**

Compare the three on speed, cost model, longevity, buyer intent and predictability (§1.5.5), then commit to a weighted recommendation and justify it with the *intent* argument — a brand-new gadget generates no organic search demand yet, so paid and social must create the demand that SEO will later harvest.

**9. Identify and explain at least five key metrics used to measure the impact and performance of content marketing efforts. How can these metrics influence future content strategies? [CIE-I 1 Jul 2024, 10 marks]**

Name traffic, engagement rate, bounce rate, lead generation and conversion rate/ROI; group them into reach & visibility, resonance & memory, and engagement & friction; and for each state explicitly how the reading changes the next content cycle. See §1.12.

**10. Imagine you are a digital marketing strategist at GreenTech Innovations, a company launching a new line of eco-friendly kitchen appliances called "EcoChef." Design a comprehensive content marketing strategy to promote these products. Include specific goals, types of content, distribution channels, and methods of engagement with your target audience. [CIE-I 1 Jul 2024, 10 marks]**

Use the eight-step framework. **Goals:** build awareness of EcoChef among urban eco-conscious households; generate 5,000 e-mail subscribers in 6 months; achieve a 3% landing-page conversion rate. **Personas:** sustainability-minded young families and first-home buyers. **Themes:** sustainable cooking, energy savings, kitchen-to-table living, product demonstrations. **Content types:** SEO blogs ("how much energy does an induction hob save"), recipe videos and reels, comparison infographics, a downloadable energy-savings calculator, webinars with chefs, and customer UGC. **Distribution:** owned (website, blog, e-mail); paid (Google Ads on high-intent appliance keywords, Instagram and YouTube ads); earned

(sustainability influencers, PR, product reviews). **Engagement:** community group, a recipe contest, responsive social customer care, and a nurture e-mail sequence. **Measurement:** reach, engagement rate, leads, conversions and content-attributed revenue, feeding back into theme and distribution improvement.

**11. What is Digital marketing? Explain the differences between Traditional Marketing and Digital Marketing. Highlight any 5 key differences. [SEE Oct/Nov 2023, Q2a, 8 marks]**

Define digital marketing (§1.1.1), then give any five differences from the table in §1.1.3 — communication direction, reach, cost, measurability and interactivity are the strongest five — each with a one-line example.

**12. List and explain various pricing strategies used in marketing management with suitable examples. [SEE Oct/Nov 2023, Q2b, 8 marks]**

**Penetration pricing** — low launch price to win share fast (Jio's initial free/low tariffs). **Skimming pricing** — high launch price harvested from early adopters, then lowered (new iPhone models). **Cost-plus pricing** — cost plus a fixed markup (retail and FMCG distribution). **Value-based pricing** — priced on perceived customer value, not cost (premium software, luxury goods). **Competitive/going-rate pricing** — matched to rivals (airlines, fuel). **Psychological pricing** — ₹999 instead of ₹1,000. **Bundle pricing** — combo packs, Microsoft 365. **Freemium** — free core, paid upgrade (Spotify, Zoom). **Dynamic pricing** — real-time adjustment by demand (Uber surge, Amazon). **Promotional/discount pricing** — temporary reductions to drive volume (Big Billion Days).

**13. Explain how content research tools help marketers discover new opportunities and gain a competitive edge. [SEE Jun/Jul 2025, Q2b, 8 marks]**

See §1.13 — the keyword sweet spot (volume × low difficulty × commercial intent), the seven ways research creates edge, and the toolset.

**14. Discuss how website analysis contributes to enhanced customer experience and conversion optimization. [SEE Jun/Jul 2025, Q2a, 8 marks]**

See §1.8 — name the tools by category, then give the six mechanisms: diagnosing friction, fixing speed, locating funnel drop-off, validating changes through A/B testing, segmenting by device and channel, and aligning content with intent.

**15. Enumerate briefly on the best practices for creating compelling and shareable content on social media platforms to increase brand visibility and engagement. [SEE Oct/Nov 2023, Q3b, 8 marks]**

Apply the 7-point quality gate; lead with visuals (visual content is 40× more likely to be shared and posts with relevant images get 94% more views); follow the 4-1-1 rule so value outweighs promotion; write for the platform rather than cross-posting blindly; hook in the first three seconds; use 1–2 targeted hashtags; post consistently at audience-active times; invite participation through questions, polls and contests; repurpose one master asset into many formats; and amplify through communities and influencers.

### HOW UNIT I IS EXAMINED

In the SEE, **Question 2 is compulsory and is always drawn from Unit I** (two sub-divisions of 8 marks each), plus roughly two Part-A objective questions. In CIE-I, Unit I typically carries the whole paper. The three highest-probability 10-mark topics are: **the eight-step content marketing strategy applied to a scenario, buyer persona creation, and traditional vs digital marketing with a transition plan**. All three have already repeated across multiple years.